in joint counterterrorism, peacekeeping and disaster management exercises between our armed forces and those of friendly countries in and around our neighbourhood and other important nations of the world has proved very beneficial. Well-orchestrated military diplomacy can help in the achievement of our foreign policy goals and in addressing the security concerns in our region.

This is particularly true in the case of countries where the military has an overarching role in policy-making or governance. I was able to make bridges for effective military-to-military cooperation between the armed forces of Algeria and India as a defence attaché. Colonel Chadli Bendjedid was the president of Algeria at that time. Due to India's moral and diplomatic support to the freedom struggle of Algeria, our standing in the Arab countries and my army background, I was able to get easy access to their military and political hierarchy.

I have been a great advocate of involving the armed forces during the evolution and formulation of our foreign policy with respect to our neighbouring countries. This will further our national interests, build mutual trust and confidence, and thereby engender peace and stability in the region. A strategic-level military-to-military dialogue helps in evolving a shared perception of emerging challenges as also the possible steps to overcome them. The process comprises high-level defence interaction with key global and regional players through exchanges at various levels. We have been pursuing these in a focused manner with our neighbours like China, Bhutan, Nepal, Afghanistan, Myanmar, Sri Lanka, and recently with Bangladesh, as also with the US, Russia, the UK, France, Japan, Australia, Singapore, Indonesia and a few other countries. With Pakistan, there have only been diplomatic parleys and a composite dialogue, which has been 'off and on' due to Pakistan's complicity in terrorist attacks against our country. We have conducted joint training exercises with many of these countries, as also with China. The agreement for this was signed between the foreign ministers of the two countries, but the modalities were concretized during my visit to China in mid-2007. Because we are regarded as a thoroughly professional and battle-experienced army, there is a great clamour among other